



Donald Howard Murray (84) died on March 2, 2004, following a long period where he selflessly acted as the primary caregiver for his wife, Dorothy, who was battling health issues. Dorothy Elliott Murray (83) died the very same day.

The couple had been married for 60 years and were rarely separated during their lifetimes. You can read more about their lives, careers, and shared passing in the [Donald Howard and Dorothy Elliot Murray Obituary](#) provided by *The Oregonian*.

<https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2026/may/23/this-day-in-history-north-central-high-school-rock/>

Public records indicate that M. Dean Rieken was a teacher in Spokane, Washington, working in the district through at least 2002, with past addresses in the city. There is no official obituary or conclusive online death record confirming his passing.

He is remembered historically in the area for his time at North Central High School. In May 1976, Rieken, acting as the Associated Student Body (ASB) faculty adviser, was featured in local media regarding an extremely close and controversial student body president election that was ultimately invalidated due to voting irregularities.

To search for potential funeral or death records, you can check the [FamilySearch Historical Records](#) to browse U.S. obituary databases or consult the Spokesman-Review Archives for regional death notices.



Mike Weir (Michael C. Weir) was a beloved teacher and coach at North Central High School in Spokane, Washington, who taught German and English, and coached wrestling, football, and softball. He was a 1957 graduate of North Central who returned to teach there after serving in the Army and earning his degrees.

Biographical & Career Information:

•**Life & Education:** Born February 20, 1939, in Spokane, WA, Mike Weir graduated from North Central High School in 1957. He served in the U.S. Army—where he played football and was stationed in Germany—and then returned to work in construction. Utilizing the GI Bill, he earned his teaching degree from Eastern Washington University and a master's degree from Whitworth University.

•**Teaching & Coaching:** He had a long, respected career teaching German and English at North Central High School, actively coaching wrestling, football, and softball. He retired from teaching in 1997, though he spent many of his summers working as a heavy machine operator on road construction projects.

•**Community Legacy:** He was remembered as a hardworking, warm, and highly active member of his community, frequently assisting neighbors with repairs and always remembered by former students.

Obituary & Memorial Details:

•**Passing:** Mike Weir passed away at the age of 83 on February 9, 2023, due to complications from surgery and septic shock.

•**Survivors:** He was preceded in death by his wife of 57 years, Sharon Weir, and several siblings. He is survived by his two daughters, Teri Fulton and Molly Bergan, along with their families.

•**Tributes:** You can read the comprehensive memorial details and view the guestbook via [Michael C Weir Obituary February 9, 2023](#) Feb 9, 2023 — He was constantly helping others with home, yard and car repairs, driving friends to the airport, shoveling driveways for neighbor... Holy Cross Funeral and Cemetery Services site, or on the [Legacy.com Spokesman-Review](#)

Mary Haugen was a well-respected educator in the Spokane Public Schools. Beginning her career as an English and drama teacher at North Central High School in 1976, she later transitioned into administration. She notably served as Principal of Salk Middle School, where she received the Washington Award for Excellence in Education before retiring in 2000.

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Educator & Mentor: During her early years at North Central High School (NC), she was remembered for shaping the English and theater departments, famously collaborating on NC student productions.

Principal at Salk: By the mid-1990s, she was the principal of Jonas Salk Middle School in Spokane. She led the school with a heavy emphasis on student safety, peer mediation, and direct communication with families.

State Recognition: In 1999, she was celebrated by the state's superintendent of public instruction and was the sole nominee from Spokane School District 81 for the Washington Award for Excellence in Education.

Legacy: She officially retired in 2000 after 13 years of leadership at Salk. The impact of her mentorship and career in Spokane lives on in the community and the lives of the students she taught.

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For a look at the history of her students and memories from her early teaching days, you can browse discussions within the North Central High School Alumni Group. To review her time at the helm of Salk Middle School, her career highlights are detailed in this Spokesman-Review feature.

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George Chalich, who taught US History and coached for 28 years in the Spokane area, passed away on January 15, 2017, at the age of 86. Born in Butte, Montana in 1930, he was a standout athlete who played collegiate basketball at the University of Washington and Gonzaga University.

Life and Career Highlights:

- Educator & Coach:** Taught and coached at Oakesdale, Mead, and North Central High Schools, where he positively impacted countless students.
- Athletic & Officiating Career:** Excelled as a basketball and baseball player, and officiated collegiate-level baseball and basketball (including the Pac-8) for 40 years.
- Personal Life:** Survived by his wife, Geraldine "Jeri," a daughter, a granddaughter, a great-grandson, and several siblings.
- Community Involvement:** Held roles such as president of the Serbian Lodge of Spokane and served on the Fairmont Memorial Association board.

You can read the full biographical tribute on the [PNW Cremation & Funeral](#) site, or view tributes and memories on [Legacy.com](#).

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<https://www.pnwcremation.com/obituaries/George-Chalich?obId=2912317>

<https://www.legacy.com/us/obituaries/sfgate/name/gerard-hughes-obituary?id=36249010>

Gerard "Jerry" Eamon de Valera Hughes passed away in Santa Rosa, California, on August 9, 2022, at the age of 78. He was an elected member of the Washington State Legislature representing Spokane before retiring to raise his children and later became a beloved public high school teacher.

Life & Career Timeline:

- Early Life:** Born in New York on February 16, 1944, to Irish immigrant parents, Jerry grew up in Rockaway Beach and later relocated with his family to San Francisco, where he excelled at baseball at St. Ignatius High School.
 - Education & Inspiration:** He attended Gonzaga University in Spokane, where a speech by President Kennedy inspired him to pursue public service.
 - Political Career:** He entered the Washington State Legislature and served two terms representing Spokane.
 - Teaching & Legacy:** After stepping away from state politics, he went on to teach history and become a beloved public high school educator (such as at North Central High School) before moving back to California in his later years.
- You can read more about his life and leave messages for the family on his official [Legacy.com Obituary Page](#) or view the registry of condolences on the [Spokesman-Review Obituary Page](#).

Jerry Hughes served in the Washington State Legislature as a State Representative from 1979 to 1982 and later as a State Senator from 1983 to 1990. Prior to his political career, he taught history at North Central High School in Spokane, Washington.

Biographical Details

- Early Career & Teaching:** Before entering state politics, Jerry Hughes worked as a public high school history teacher at North Central High School in Spokane, WA.
 - Political Run:** Although he made an unsuccessful run for State Representative in 1976, he successfully ran for the State House representing Spokane in 1978.
 - Legislative Service:** He served in the Washington House of Representatives before moving to the Washington State Senate, serving from 1983 through 1990.
 - Later Life:** After stepping down from the legislature, Hughes went on to teach political science at Gonzaga University in Spokane.
- Because he served in office decades ago and is a private citizen, comprehensive biographical archives or an obituary for him are not widely published online. To track down further specific details or verify public records, you can review his legislative profile via the Washington State Legislature or research past Spokane news archives.

Burrill Dean Exley (1923–1997) was a beloved math teacher, coach, and department head at North Central High School in Spokane from 1950 to 1978.

Biographical Highlights:

- Early Life & Service:** Born in Colville, Washington, he was a veteran of World War II.
- Career:** He taught algebra and geometry at North Central High School for 28 years. Afterward, he taught at Kennedy High School in Burien, Washington, from 1980 to 1985.
- Legacy:** He was so well-regarded in the Pacific Northwest that Exley Falls—a 40-foot waterfall in Pend Oreille County, Washington—is officially named after him.

John Luppert taught Music, Band, and Orchestra at [North Central High School](#) in Spokane, Washington. Luppert, an alumnus of Spokane schools, joined North Central as band director in the 1970s, making an impact by reorganizing the music program and eliminating the Cadet Band.

Life and Career:

John Henry Luppert Sr. was born, raised, and spent most of his life in Spokane, WA. A talented musician from a young age, he played clarinet and participated in the All-City band. He later married Nan Comeaux, whom he met in the band.

Obituary and Legacy:

John Luppert Sr. passed away in a tragic car accident in Spokane on September 10, 1996. He was driving on the South Hill when his station wagon collided with another car at the 16th Avenue and Cedar Street intersection. At the time of his passing, he was survived by his wife, four children, and three step-children. His legacy as a musician and local educator continues to be remembered by his former students. Years later, his spirit for adventure—best exemplified when he tossed a message into the ocean in 1999 that was recovered in Alaska 18 years later—was featured and celebrated in [The Spokesman-Review](#). You can read additional details or view historical tributes via the [John Henry Luppert, Sr. Obituary](#) on Newspapers.com.

Michael W. Caldwell (June 6, 1939 – May 14, 2018) was a beloved music educator who taught choir and singing at North Central High School in Spokane, Washington, for over 30 years.

His biography and legacy include several key milestones:

- Education:** Born in Wenatchee, Washington, he graduated from Washington State University in 1962 (where he studied music) and later earned a Master's degree from Eastern Washington University.
- Teaching Career:** After starting out at Sumner High School, he spent the bulk of his career guiding choir and singing students at North Central High School. In retirement, he taught as an adjunct instructor at Spokane Community College and gave private piano lessons.
- Community & Performance:** A massive fixture in the Spokane arts scene, Mike directed several local church choirs and the American German Society Choir. He sang with the Spokane Chorale for 50 years, performed in the Spokane Civic Light Opera and Spokane City Theater, directed a joint American/Canadian choir at Expo '74, and even performed at Carnegie Hall.
- Family & Legacy:** He was survived by his wife Elizabeth, children, stepchildren, and numerous grandchildren.

You can read his full life story or sign his digital memorial guestbook on the [Lakeview Funeral Home](#) obituary page, or review additional historical information via the [Legacy.com Spokesman-Review](#) notice.

Orval N.P. Theisen was a long-time physics and science teacher at North Central High School in Spokane, Washington. Born in South Dakota in 1916, he passed away in Spokane in August 2007 at the age of 91.

His biographical and historical background details include:

- Background & Education:** Orval N.P. Theisen was born in Erwin, Kingsbury, South Dakota on January 14, 1916.
- Early Career & Military:** Before his teaching career, he served in the U.S. military, including the Army Air Corps and later the Air Force, from January 1943 to October 1945. He served as a radio operator and gunner on B-17s, participating in 35 bombing missions over central Europe.
- Personal Life:** He married Anna Aileene Cantlon in Spokane on January 5, 1946.
- Teaching Career:** He spent decades as a physics and science instructor at North Central High School, where he taught alongside science department head Ernest Hix. He was an active educator, even publishing in *The Physics Teacher* journal in the early 1970s.
- Death:** He died on August 7, 2007, and was laid to rest in the Spokane area.

You can review his brief family and historical timeline via the [FamilySearch Life History for Orval Theisen](#).

Norman W. Erickson was a business and mathematics teacher at North Central High School in Spokane from 1956 until his retirement in 1979. He passed away in July 1999. He is survived by his wife, Marjorie (Henniger) Erickson, four children, and five grandchildren.

Additional biographical and obituary details include:

- Early Life & Education:** He was a Spokane native who initially worked for Madison Lumber in 1948 and Watson Management in 1950. He later attended Washington State University and Eastern Washington University, where he earned his teaching degree in 1956.
- Professional Associations:** During his career, he was a member of the Retired Teachers, Spokane Education, and Washington Education associations, as well as the Moose Lodge.
- Obituary:** The full death notice was published on July 13, 1999, and is accessible in the [Spokesman-Review Archives](#).

John P. Rodkey served as the beloved principal of North Central High School in Spokane, Washington, from 1959 until 1979. Born in 1921, he passed away on May 16, 2012. Before his long career in education, he served as a radio operator in the Army Air Forces during WWII.

Life and Legacy:

- Background:** Born on a farm in Colorado, his family relocated to Post Falls, Idaho, during the Great Depression.
 - Career:** He spent 20 years at the helm of North Central High School, bringing deep compassion, grace, and energy to the student body.
 - Personal Life:** He was married, raised three children, and was a dedicated member of his church who valued faith, learning, and storytelling.
- You can read more about his remarkable life or pay tribute through the full [Obituary for John P. Rodkey](#) published by Heritage Funeral & Cremation, or explore his legacy feature in the [Spokesman-Review](#).

<https://www.legacy.com/us/obituaries/spokesman/name/john-rodkey-obituary?id=15851919>

<https://www.legacy.com/funeral-homes/obituaries/name/john-rodkey-obituary?pid=157749061&v=batesville&view=guestbook>

<https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2012/jan/26/education-of-a-lifetime>

<https://www.heritagefunerals.com/obituaries/john-p-rodkey-obid-3033903>

oseph "Joe" Schauble was a beloved math teacher and coach who taught for 38 years, spending 30 of them at North Central High School before retiring in 1996. He passed away peacefully in his sleep at age 89 on February 7, 2024.

Early Life & Education

- Born:** June 14, 1934, in Killdeer, North Dakota.
- Relocation:** Moved to St. John, Washington, in 1937.
- College:** Attended Gonzaga University on a partial basketball scholarship, graduating in 1956. He and his two older brothers, Bill and Rollin, hold the distinct honor of being the only set of three brothers to play basketball for the Zags. He also played baseball for four years.
- Degrees:** Earned a master's degree in school administration, though he ultimately preferred the classroom and court over administration.

Teaching & Coaching Career

- Tenure:** Taught for 38 years, with the final 30 years spent teaching math at North Central High School in Spokane, Washington.
 - Athletics:** Coached five different sports ranging from elementary school to college, both in JV and Varsity, and across parochial and public schools.
- You can read the full, comprehensive tribute in the [Legacy.com Obituary](#) hosted by The Spokesman-Review.

https://ia800500.us.archive.org/19/items/SPLYearbooksNorthCentral1958/SPL_Yearbooks_North_Central_1958_text.pdf